I sat on a chair by the verandah and asked the person sitting next to me if he had a cigarette. He looked around, and reluctantly pulled out a cigarette and a matchbox from his pocket for me. I lit the cigarette and inhaled deep. I saw sub-inspector Thambi Durgadutt moving in and out of that police office. He avoided my gaze.

After a few minutes, Jogesh told me that the ISRO spy case has been formally handed over to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI). The agency will soon take custody of me and the other accused. I did not know whether to feel happy or sad.

We were asked to get into a van. The destination was Pallipuram camp, another den of criminal interrogation in Trivandrum. The van entered through a wrong gate and had to return and take the right entrance. Everyone, including the policemen in the van, was silent. It was eerie.

We were led to the first floor of a two-storey building on the campus. At the landing on the first floor, someone received us with the simple ceremony of handcuffing us. I tried to resist, but immediately yielded to the coldness of the metal on my wrist.

'Handcuffing is a formality, sir,' he said.

Much like the experience in the magistrate court the day after my arrest, I felt I was watching myself in handcuffs. I felt like a criminal.

Now the CBI had the accused in different rooms at Pallippuram. They were:

Mariam Rasheed (A1)
Fauziyya Hassan (A2)
D Sasikumaran (A3)
K Chandrasekhar (A4)
S Nambi Narayanan (A5)
S K Sharma (A6)

NEW LESSONS, OLD DREAMS

'*Mate, you exposed me*.'